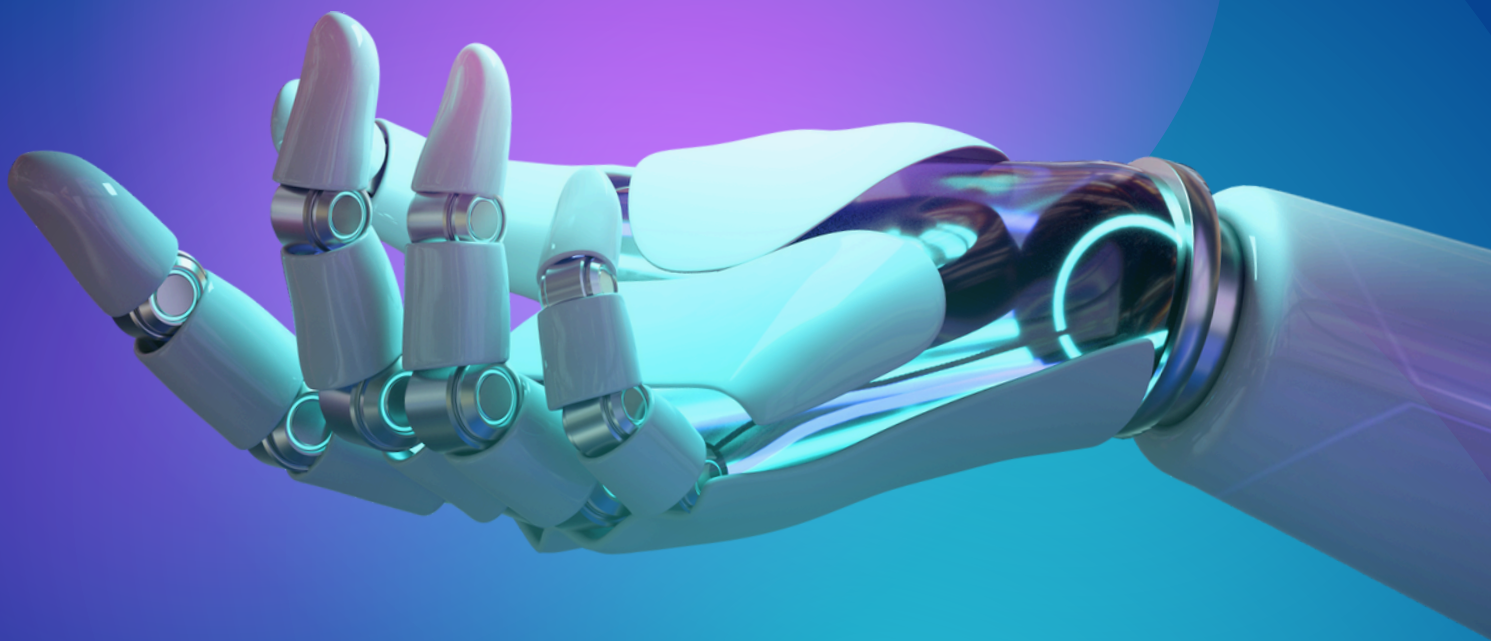


PROGRAMMING 3C

P.O.E PART 1

RESEARCH



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P.O.E PART 1**RESEARCH****AC Tech:**

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1. Introduction

This research aims to determine the best effective methods for developing a personal budgeting application that is both intuitive and engaging. This application will integrate automation, real-time monitoring, and gamification to improve the budgeting experience. This will be accomplished by exploring three widely used personal budgeting apps available for the Android operating system: Wallet by BudgetBakers, Money Tracker - Expense & Budget, and YNAB (You Need a Budget). We will analyse their features, strengths, weaknesses, and innovative features. By comparing these three apps, this study will identify what makes a budgeting tool successful and identify key features that improve user experience, encourage financial responsibility, and make budgeting more appealing and engaging. The results will be used as a foundation for the creation of our budgeting application that will assist users in tracking and managing their finances and ensures that they remain active in their financial journey.

2. Research on each apps**Wallet by BudgetBakers****a. Overview – Wallet by BudgetBakers**

Wallet by BudgetBakers is a comprehensive personal finance management app designed to help users track their expenses, create budgets (as per Figure 1.1 and 1.2) and analyse financial habits. The app supports both manual expense entry (as per Figure 1.3 and 1.4) and automatic bank synchronization (as per Figure 1.5), making it convenient for users to monitor their financial activity in real-time. The wallet offers user-friendly instruments for budgeting, financial planning, and debt management, enabling users to manage their spending effectively. Emphasizing financial insights. The wallet produces comprehensive reports, interactive graphs, and AI-generated suggestions to assist users in enhancing their financial management abilities (see to Figure 1.6). It is accessible on various platforms, including Android, iOS, and web, facilitating effortless access to financial data from any location (Erickson, 2022).

Screenshots with descriptions:

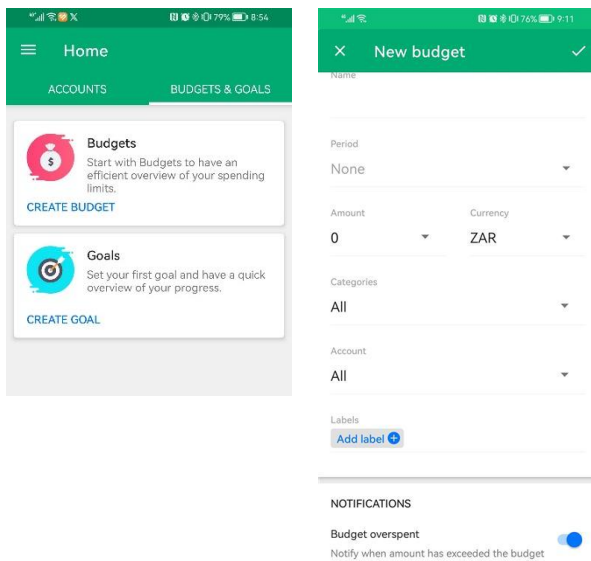


Figure 1.1 and 1.2: The user can create budgets and create goals by manually enter the budget details including budget name, amount and category including the ability to have notifications of budget overspend and personalization of the budget with a label.

(BudgetBakers, 2014)

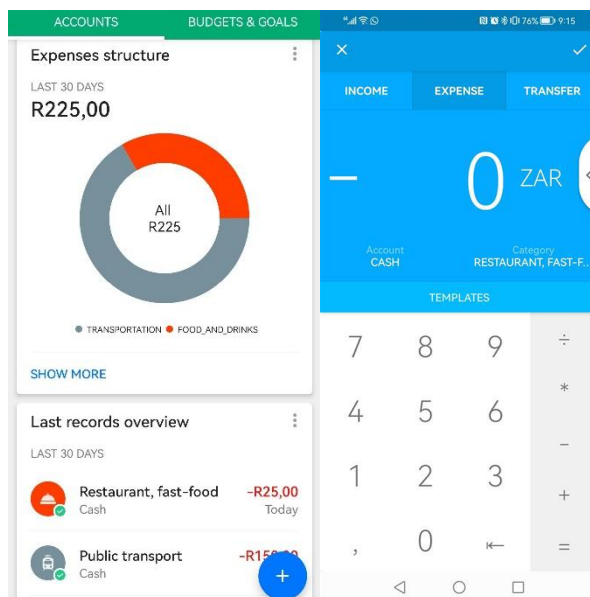


Figure 1.3 and 1.4: The user can manually enter expenses, incomes and transfers using the (+) button, and then interactive charts will display and the latest records with be displayed.

(BudgetBakers, 2014)

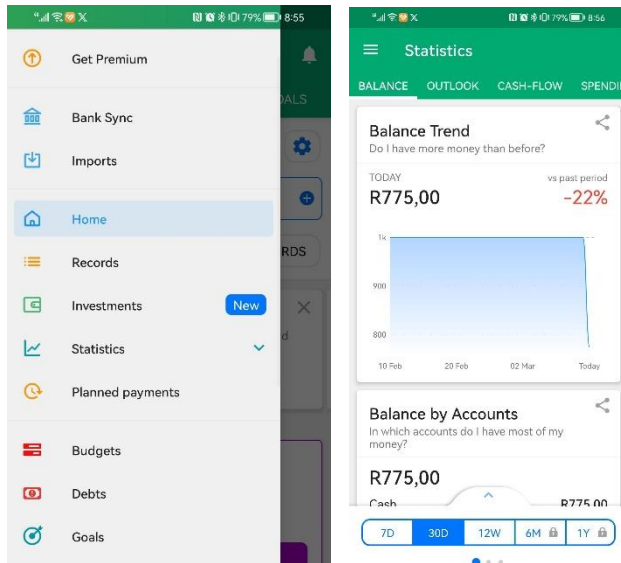


Figure.1.5 and 1.6: The user has a selection of tab features from budgeting tools to debt management. As well as access to generated reports and statistics based on financial movements.

(BudgetBakers, 2014)

b. Strengths and weaknesses – Wallet by BudgetBakers

Strengths:

- **Financial Reports & AI Insights:** Wallet by BudgetBakers gives users a detailed look at their spending, which helps them see trends in the way they handle their money. AI-powered insights give users smart suggestions based on their past spending, letting them know when they might be spending too much or when they have chances to save money. These reports help users make more realistic budgets and plan their finances better (BudgetBakers, 2022).
- **Cloud Backup & Multi-Device Support:** All financial data is securely kept in the cloud, preventing data loss from device failure or unintentional deletion. Users can seamlessly access and update their budgets, transactions, and reports from multiple devices, ensuring they always have the latest financial information. This feature is particularly useful for those who switch between a smartphone, tablet, and computer (BudgetBakers, 2022).
- **Bill & Subscription Tracking:** Users of the app can check and control regular payments like utilities, rent, and streaming services. Wallet helps people avoid late fees and keep track of how much they spend on payments by reminding them of due dates and recording their spending. This avoids needless fees for services either forgotten or unneeded (BudgetBakers, 2022).
- **Export & Report Generation:** Users can easily export their transaction history in formats like CSV and PDF, making it convenient for budgeting, tax filing, or financial reviews. This feature is especially useful for professionals who need to keep records of their business expenses or those who want to analyse their spending outside the app (BudgetBakers, 2022).

Weaknesses:

- **Bank Syncing Requires Premium Subscription:** One of the biggest limitations of Wallet by BudgetBakers is that automatic bank synchronization is only available with a paid subscription. Free users must manually enter their transactions, which can be time-consuming and may discourage consistent tracking. This creates a barrier for those looking for a fully automated budgeting experience without paying for premium features (Jakub A. Ě, 2020).
- **Complex Interface for Beginners:** Wallet offers a wide range of features, which can be overwhelming for first-time users. The layout includes multiple menus, reports, and customization options, making it less intuitive for people new to budgeting apps. Without a simple onboarding process or guided tutorials, some users may struggle to navigate the app efficiently (Jakub A. Ě, 2020).
- **Limited Gamification Features:** Unlike some modern budgeting apps that use challenges, badges, or rewards, Wallet lacks strong gamification elements to keep users engaged. Since financial management can often feel tedious, the absence of interactive motivation tools may result in users losing interest over time. Adding elements like achievement badges for staying within budget or daily streaks for logging expenses could make budgeting more enjoyable (Jakub A. Ě, 2020).
- **Receipt Scanning is Basic:** While Wallet allows users to upload receipts, its scanning capabilities are limited. It does not have advanced OCR (Optical Character Recognition) technology, meaning users must manually enter transaction details instead of having them auto extracted. This adds extra effort and reduces the convenience of quick expense tracking, especially for users who frequently rely on receipts for budgeting (Jakub A. Ě, 2020).

c. Innovative features – Wallet by BudgetBakers

- **Shared Accounts & Family Budgeting:** Users can create shared budgets for households, couples, or teams, allowing financial transparency and collaboration (BudgetBakers, 2024).
- **Financial Insights driven by Artificial Intelligence:** The app provides personalized recommendations and spending analysis based on user behaviour (BudgetBakers, 2024).
- **Multi-Currency & International Support:** Wallet allows users to manage multiple currency accounts, making it useful for travellers and international users (BudgetBakers, 2024).
- **Real-Time Budget Adjustments:** The software continuously adjusts budgets in response to differences in income and expenses, assisting users in maintaining financial stability (BudgetBakers, 2024).
- **Expense Tracker:** A dedicated feature for monitoring recurring expenses like streaming services, gym memberships, or electricity and water bills, preventing overspending (BudgetBakers, 2024)
- **Comprehensive Data Export Alternates:** Users can generate custom reports and export their financial data in various formats for tax filing or financial reviews (BudgetBakers, 2024).

Money Tracker - Expense & Budget by Horoscope365

a. Overview – Money Tracker - Expense & Budget by Horoscope365

Created by Horoscope365, the free personal financial software "Money Tracker - Expense & Budget" has been accessible on Google Play since 2020. The software features dynamic charts and reports that assist users in tracking their daily expenses, managing various accounts, creating budgets, planning payments, and identifying trends in their finances (Horoscope365, 2020).

With over a million downloads, it's a well-known choice for people who want an easy but powerful tool for managing their money. The application is compatible with different types of accounts, including bank accounts, e-wallets, cash, and bitcoin wallets, making it suitable for various financial requirements. The double-entry tracking feature in the app is really great because it ensures that all transactions are accurately recorded, and the balance gets updated immediately. It's useful for anyone who works with various currencies since it can manage multiple ones effectively (Horoscope365, 2020).

The software offers a free version that includes basic tools, along with a paid version that unlocks additional features like data sharing and advanced analytics capabilities (Horoscope365, 2020).

Screenshots with descriptions:

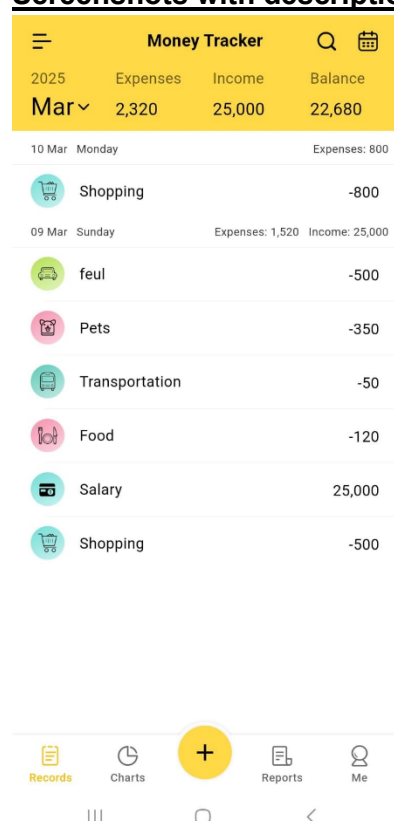


Figure 1.1 depicts the dashboard overview of that app and is the first screen displayed when app is opened. It displays total income, expenses, and the remaining balance for the selected period (daily, weekly, or monthly). It's also easy for users to keep track of their spending in real time because a list of recent transactions is shown.

(Horoscope365, 2020)

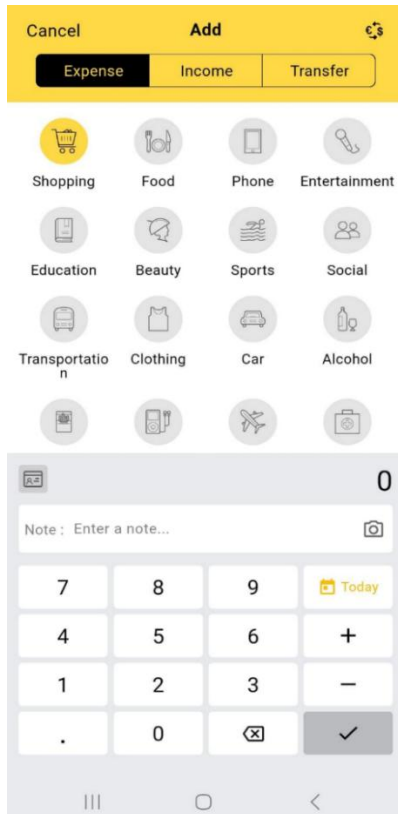


Figure 1.2 displays a screen that allows users to log a new transaction easily. Users can choose a type of income or expense, enter the amount, and write a note to help them remember. You can add pictures of records or bills to the app, which makes it useful for keeping track of business costs or guarantees. Certain funds, like cash, a bank account, or an e-wallet, can be linked to transactions.

(Horoscope365, 2020)

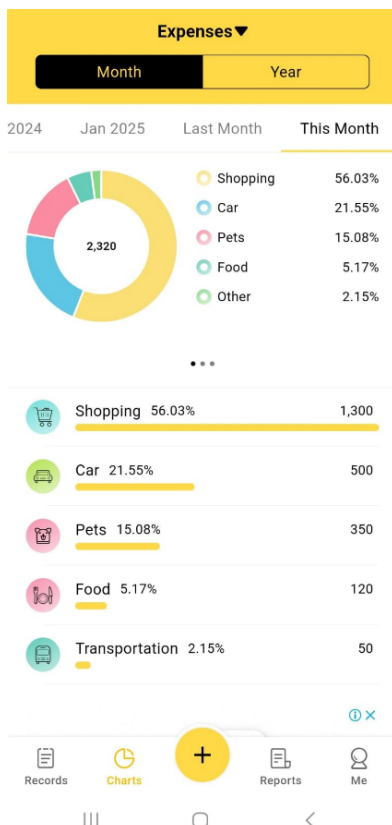


Figure 1.3 displays the financial data in graphical forms of interactive charts and graphs, to help users visualize their income and spending trends. The data is displayed in different types of graphs, namely: Pie Charts, Stacked Bar Charts Bar Graphs and Line Charts.

(Horoscope365, 2020)

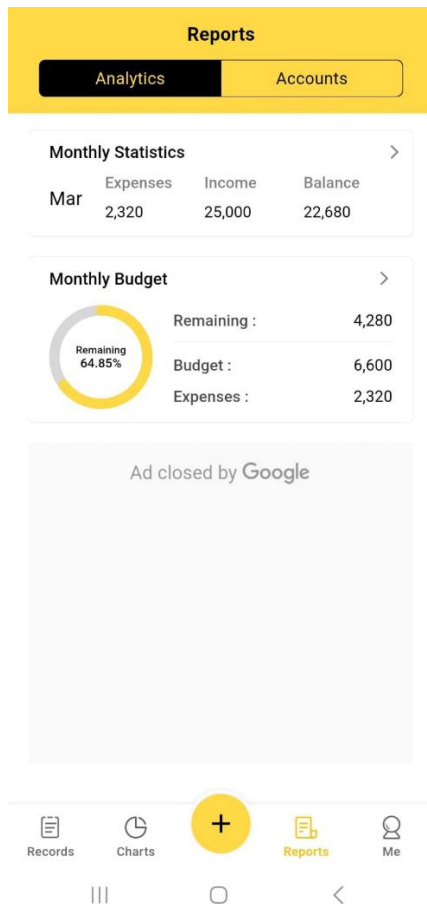


Figure 1.4 display the screen providing users Reporting and Analytics services. This screen provides users detailed insights into how they spend their money over different periods. The app lets users look at their buying patterns and see where they spend the most. Looking a specific financial information, users can narrow down records by date range, account type, or group

(Horoscope365, 2020)

b. Strengths and weaknesses – Money Tracker by Horoscope365

Strengths:

- **Comprehensive Features for Personal Finance Management:** The app goes beyond merely tracking expenses; it also includes budgeting tools to help you avoid overspending. Managing multiple accounts allows you to monitor your finances across several accounts. There is scheduled bill payments and regular cost notes that are arranged in advance. This really serves as a convenient hub for anyone looking to manage all their finances in a single location (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Advanced Data Visualization & Reports:** The app has comprehensive charts and reports that make it easier to look at how money is spent. With visually appealing views, users can see how their finances are changing over time, find places where they are spending too much, and make changes to their budgets as needed The app has comprehensive charts and reports that make it easier to look at how money is spent. With visually appealing views, users can see how their finances are changing over time, find places where they are spending too much, and make changes to their budgets as needed (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Customizable Categories and Multi-Currency Support:** People can create personalized categories for their income and expenses, using their own symbols to keep track of their activities with icons easily. The software is really useful for people who move around or handle international money since it works in multiple countries.

It's possible to adjust the exchange rates immediately for effective monitoring (Horoscope365, 2020).

- **Secure Cloud Backup & Multi-Device Syncing:** Cloud backup means users never have to worry about losing their banking information. The app syncs automatically across multiple devices, so users can see their most recent spending and activities from any device, at any time (Horoscope365, 2020).

Weaknesses:

- **Inconsistent Category Icon Colours:** I've noticed that custom category icons change colours randomly when I use this app, which makes it look crowded and confused. This can make it harder to quickly find cost groups, which can make records less easy to read (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Stability Issues and App Crashes:** Based on personal usage the app slows or crashes, especially when there is movement from one area to another. Sometimes the app would close without warning after only a few minutes, which can be frustrating when trying to enter transactions. These issues with speed and delays make the app less efficient and harder to use, especially for people who need to keep track of a lot of transactions every day (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Lack of Automatic Bank Synchronization:** The application calls for manually entering revenue and spending, which might take time and be prone to errors made by humans. Many contemporary financial applications import real-time transactions automatically syncing with credit cards and bank accounts. Users without this function may overlook monitoring of their finances by forgetting to record costs. For consumers with many bank accounts, this also makes it less handy as they have to personally update every one of them (Horoscope365, 2020).'

c. Innovative features – Budget Tracker by Horoscope365

- **Receipt and Warranty Tracking:** Users can add pictures of receipts, bills, or warranty papers to transactions. All of your proof of purchase is kept in one place, which is helpful for business owners, tax tracking, and people making insurance claims (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Secure Backup and Syncing Across Devices:** The app syncs with the cloud, so users can view their banking information from different platforms. People who use Google Drive or Dropbox can back up their data so that if they change phones, they don't lose their financial records (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Scheduled Payments and Reminders:** This app allows people to set up automatic payments for things like rent, bills, or services. Automatic reminders help people pay their bills on time, so they don't have to pay late fees (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Double-Entry Bookkeeping System:** This budgeting app uses a double-entry system instead of a single-entry system like most others. This makes sure that every financial activity has a matching record. This method makes sure that financial records are correct and avoids mistakes (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **AI-Powered Expense Categorization:** AI and machine learning are used by the app to automatically put costs into the right category based on the details of each transaction. As users enter costs, the system learns how much they spend and offers groups, which makes it easier to do things by hand. Eventually, the AI

changes and gets better, which makes tracking the budget more accurate. By showing spending patterns, this tool helps users make smart financial choices (Horoscope365, 2020).

YNAB (You Need A Budget) by Jesse Mecham

a. Overview – YNAB by Jesse Mecham

Following a zero-based budgeting approach, YNAB (You Need A Budget) is a personal budget tracker that assigns the entire user income to categories, therefore guaranteeing that not a cent goes unaccounted for. YNAB tracks money easily as it integrates credit cards, loans, cheque and savings accounts. This approach is a type of financial literacy that promotes thoughtful spending (NerdWallet, 2025). As soon as a user gets paid, users can allocate their money into expenses, savings, and debt.

Screenshots with descriptions:

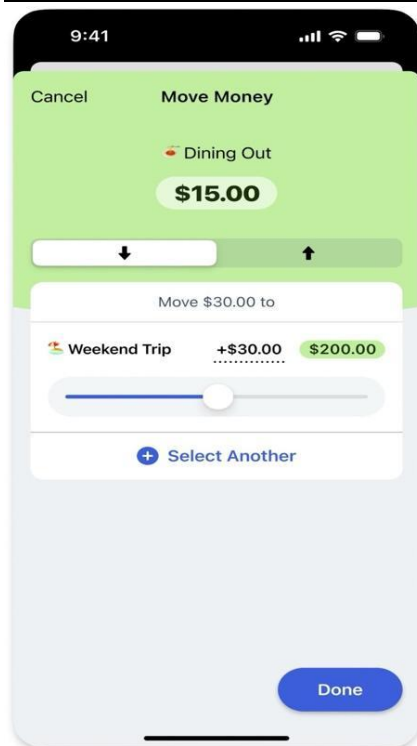


Figure 1.1 shows YNAB's fund transfer functionality, which enables users to reallocate funds across budget categories in real time. In this screenshot, \$15.00 is transferred from the "Dining Out" category to the "Weekend Trip" category, showcasing the app's ability to react to changing financial circumstances.

(Jesse Mecham, 2015)

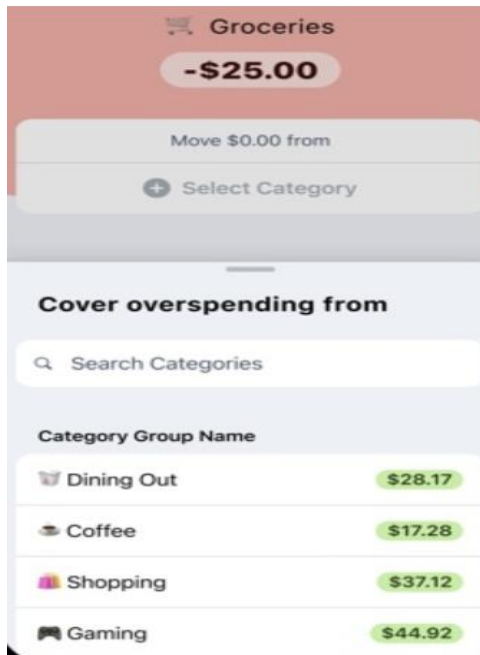


Figure 1.2 displays the Overspending Adjustment feature in YNAB, which allows users to cover overspending by reallocating funds from other budget categories.

(Jesse Mecham, 2015)

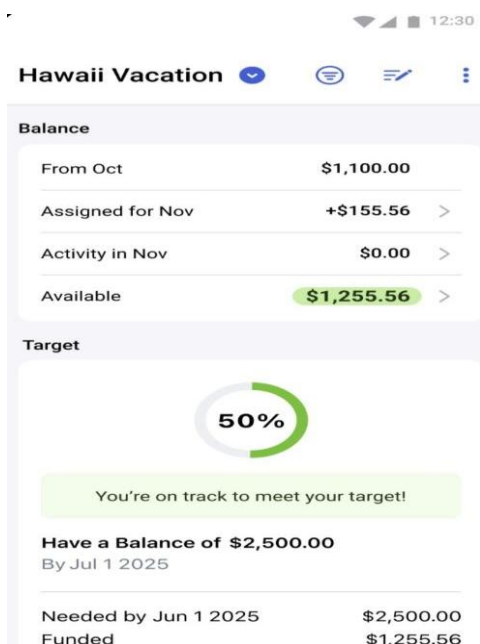


Figure 1.3 shows the Goal-Based Budgeting function in YNAB, which allows users to define, track, and manage savings objectives for potential expenses. The app displays a visual progress indicator as well as detailed breakdowns of how much money has been saved and how much still needs to be saved (Business Insider, 2024).

(Jesse Mecham, 2015)

b. Strengths and weaknesses – YNAB by Jesse Mecham

Strengths:

- **Bank Integration:** Users have the facility to connect their bank account and credit cards to the app that enables automatic recognition of all transactions and helping them to keep their expenditure in check (Business Insider, 2024).
- **Proactive Financial Planning:** Compared to many budgeting programs which only track past transactions, YNAB focuses on planning future transactions (NerdWallet, 2025).
- **Customisable budgeting system:** Users can create specific categories for daily expenses, debt repayment, or savings (NerdWallet, 2025).
- **Multi-Device and OS Accessibility:** The app is available for both Android and IOS operating systems. It is also available on smartphones, tablets, smartwatches, and Alexa devices, making it easy to manage budgets on the go (Business Insider, 2024).

Weaknesses:

- **Requires continuous management:** Unlike other budgeting apps that automate the process, YNAB is a manual process requiring users to be more hands on (Business Insider, 2024).
- **Expensive with no free version of the app:** YNAB's subscription charge is \$14.99 per month or \$99 per year, making it more expensive than other budgeting apps (Business Insider, 2024).
- **Restricted to Zero-Based Budgeting:** The app's functionality is confined to zero-based budgeting, making it less appealing for users who prefer other budgeting strategies (Business Insider, 2024).

c. Innovative features – YNAB by Jesse Mecham

- **Interactive Visual Tracking:** YNAB makes budgeting visually intuitive by using a colour-coded progress bar system (using yellow for incomplete, green for completed, and red for overspending) (Business Insider, 2024).
- **Flexible Budget Adjustments:** YNAB lets users transfer funds between categories in real time, making it responsive to unforeseen changes in the user's financial situation (NerdWallet, 2025).
- **Budgeting-Related Educational Support for Users:** YNAB provides a variety of online training, workshops, and customer support to assist users with the budgeting process (NerdWallet, 2025).
- **Spending Trend Reports and Net Worth Graphs:** The YNAB app includes extensive expenditure information, allowing users to track their spending patterns as they evolve in the form of reports and graphs (Business Insider, 2024).

3. Infographic

A COMPARISON OF Existing Budget Apps

App Overview

YNAB (You Need A Budget)



A zero-based budgeting app that focuses on hands-on financial planning, real-time fund allocation, and strict expense tracking (NerdWallet, 2025).

Money Tracker



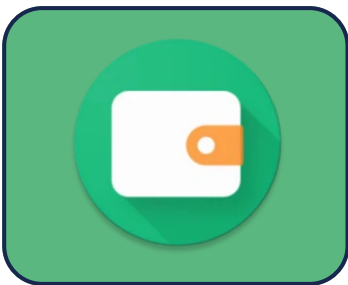
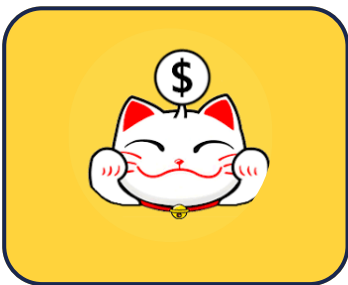
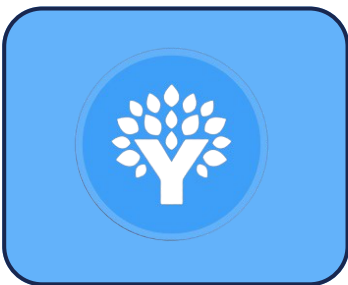
A free, user-friendly expense tracker with multi-currency support, receipt scanning, and interactive financial charts (Horoscope365, 2020).

Wallet by BudgetBakers



A comprehensive budgeting app with AI-driven insights, bank synchronization, and detailed financial reports (BudgetBakers, 2022).

Similarities between the Apps



Multi-Device Access : Available on both Android and iOS.

Expense Tracking & Budgeting – All apps let users log expenses and create budgets.

Manual Expense Entry : All apps allow users to input expenses manually.

Cloud Backup and Data Syncing: Ensures data is secure and accessible from multiple devices.

Customizable Expense Categories and Icons: All three apps allow users to create custom categories for tracking expenses, with Wallet and Money Tracker providing additional options for custom icons and personalization.

(BudgetBakers, 2022; Horoscope365, 2020; NerdWallet, 2025).

Key Differences

	YNAB (NerdWallet, 2025)	Money Tracker (Horoscope365, 2020)	Wallet by BudgetBakers (BudgetBakers, 2022)
Bank Syncing:	Automatic bank transaction syncing	No bank syncing, manual entry required	Bank syncing available
Pricing Model:	Paid only	Free with an optional premium version	Free with optional premium subscription
AI & Financial Insights:	No AI insights, requires manual categorization	Basic financial data visualization, no AI insights	AI-powered financial analysis and recommendations

4. The best features to be included in our application – BudgetBuddy

- **Feedback system for users:** The Dark Mode Scheduler will switch between light and dark modes based on time of day or user preferences. For instance, dark mode could be enabled at night for easier viewing in low-light environments, while light mode is used during the day for better visibility in bright settings. Users can also manually toggle this feature to suit their preferences. This feature enhances the user experience by offering a comfortable viewing environment that reduces eye strain in different lighting conditions, ensuring the app remains user-friendly at all times of day (Piluta, 2021).
- **Personalize User Profile Picture:** The app will allow for a more personalized user experience; users will have the option to upload a custom display picture (profile picture) or select from a pre-provided collection of images. This feature allows users to express their individuality within the app, making the experience feel more personal. The ability to choose a display picture can make users feel more connected to the app, encouraging frequent use and engagement (Piluta, 2021).
- **Customized Category pictures:** Similar to the profile picture feature, users will be able to upload custom images for their expense categories (for example: Groceries, Transport) or select from a library of images provided within the app. This feature enables users to visually represent each category in a way that resonates with them, helping to organize their expenses in a more intuitive and personalized manner. This will enhance the user interface, making it visually appealing and user-friendly (Piluta, 2021).
- **Introduce a Dark Mode Scheduler:** The Dark Mode Scheduler will switch between light and dark modes based on time of day or user preferences. For instance, dark mode could be enabled at night for easier viewing in low-light environments, while light mode is used during the day for better visibility in bright settings. Users can also manually toggle this feature to suit their preferences. This feature enhances the user experience by offering a comfortable viewing environment that reduces eye strain in different lighting conditions, ensuring the app remains user-friendly at all times of day (Piluta, 2021).
- **Saving Tracking:** To encourage users to save money, a saving tracking feature will allow users to set specific savings goals (e.g., saving R500 by the end of the month). A progress meter or challenge ring will visually display the progress toward the goal. As users contribute to their savings, the ring will fill up, giving them a tangible sense of achievement. Additionally, once users complete certain savings milestones, they will unlock secret achievements or rewards, adding an element of gamification to the process. This feature motivates users to keep working towards their savings goals while making the experience more engaging and fun (Piluta, 2021).
- **Scheduled Payments:** Users can automate recurring expenses like rent, bills, and subscriptions, ensuring payments are made on time without manual entry. This helps with better financial planning and avoids missed payments (Horoscope365, 2020).
- **Reminders:** The app provides automatic reminders for upcoming bills. Users receive notifications before due dates, helping them avoid late fees and penalties. These reminders ensure that even non-automated expenses, such as one-time payments, are not forgotten, making financial management more reliable (Horoscope365, 2020).

- **Interactive Visual Budgeting & Financial Insights:** The apps combine colour-coded progress bars (yellow for incomplete, green for completed, red for overspending) with detailed spending reports and net worth graphs. This real-time visual tracking and financial analysis help users monitor budgets, identify trends, and make informed financial decisions (Business Insider, 2024).
- **Multi-Profile User Support:** Whether personal, family, or company budgeting, the application lets users establish and move between many different accounts, therefore meeting various financial demands. Every profile guarantees a customized experience for people and businesses equally by including their own sources of income, cost categories, and financial objectives (BudgetBakers, 2024).
- **Smart Transaction Search & Filters:** The app allows users to search for expenses using keywords, dates, and amounts. Makes it easy to find specific transactions quickly. Add advanced filtering options (for example: "Find all transactions over R50 in the last 3 months") (Horoscope365, 2020).

5. Conclusion

This research examined three widely used personal budgeting applications: Wallet by BudgetBakers, Money Tracker - Expense & Budget, and YNAB (You Need a Budget), to assess their strengths, weaknesses, and innovative features in helping users manage their finances. Each app offers unique functionalities, including AI-powered financial insights, multi-device compatibility, interactive planning tools, and automatic expense tracking, which contribute to an enhanced budgeting experience. By analysing and comparing these apps, we identified key features essential for creating an efficient, user-friendly, and engaging personal budget tracker. The selected features such as expense categorization, interactive visual budgeting, multi-profile support, and scheduled payments with notifications, form the foundation for developing a budgeting app that is both functional and appealing. This research serves as a blueprint for the next stages of development, guiding the planning, design, and implementation of a budgeting app that integrates the most effective industry practices. By combining gamification elements, real-time financial tracking, and an intuitive user interface, the final application will empower users to take control of their finances in a way that is both efficient and engaging (BudgetBakers, 2024) (Horoscope365, 2020) (NerdWallet, 2025).

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Annexure: Disclosure of AI Usage in my Assessment

1. Section(s) within the assessment in which generative AI was used

- Section(s) within the assessment in which generative AI was used, Research POE PART 1

2. Name of AI tool(s) used

- QuillBot Paraphrasing Tool

3. Purpose/intention behind use

- Paraphrasing, correcting grammar and spelling;

4. Date(s) in which generative AI was used

- From 27 February 2025 - 15 March 2025.

5. Link QuilBot paraphrasing tool

- <https://quillbot.com/paraphrasing-tool>